Behl, the GPO (gun position officer), now deployed the gunners in a defensive position around the guns. His men had salvaged some eighty-odd rounds, though unknown to them, another 417 shells were lying at the drop zone waiting for porters. Without specific coordinates to fire at, Lieutenant Behl and his men were helpless spectators as the battle unfolded. As a result, not a single shot could be fired in support of 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR on the morning of 20 October.

In the initial shelling, two of Behl's men, Gunner Avtar Singh and Radio Operator Chamkar Singh, had been hit by splinters. Getting the two casualties across to the medical post was impossible as shells were landing all around them regularly. The young officer poured brandy on the wounds and with his bare hands pulled out the big pieces of shrapnel before patching up the two men with field dressings. By then it was almost 9 a.m. and there was still no communication with anybody. His men kept trying to make contact with Captain Talwar but continued to draw a blank. Without a target, engaging the Chinese was just not possible.

After a while, the gunners saw a Bell two-seater helicopter approaching the helipad. By then Tsangdhar was reverberating with small arms fire, Chinese activity being visible in what was known as the black rock area. The intensity of the shelling had lessened, but was occurring sporadically. There was no sign of the helicopter taking off again, so Behl sent two men to see what had happened. They reported that the helicopter was standing at the helipad, but the pilot and another officer in a red turban were lying dead next to it.

The gunners were not the only ones still standing resolutely at their positions. A soldier started to crawl towards Behl's trench, shouting at them so they wouldn't shoot at him by mistake. He was the battery havildar major (BHM) of the mortar battery that was deployed just ahead of the guns. The NCO wanted to know what the latest position was. Behl had just finished telling the soldier that his communication lines had been cut, when small arms fire killed the BHM on the spot. Realizing that the situation was dire, Behl ordered both the guns to fire at the black rock area. The guns had barely fired ten rounds each, when a second Bell helicopter started approaching Tsangdhar. The gunners could see it sharply bank away as Chinese MMGs from various positions engaged it.

Describing the scene at Tsangdhar shortly after mid-day, Behl said: 'The withdrawal from Tsangdhar and areas below had started along the track